

American Government





About the Course

Students will gain a better understanding of the foundation of American democracy as they learn about the key principles of the Constitution, including the separation of powers, checks and balances, and the responsibilities of each branch of government. There will be a special focus on the Bill of Rights so students understand their rights as citizens and the limits of the government. Supplemental material is provided through articles, videos, and Supreme Court cases. Students will engage with these ideas using their Citizenship notebook.

This topic is included in the following course(s): Citizenship: Grade 7 (U.S.)



Placement & Combining Tips

If 8th-grade students have not taken this course or studied the Constitution, they should consider taking it instead of the 8th-grade option.



Scheduling

GRADE	SCHEDULE INFO.	BOOKS
7	American Government: Grade 7 1 time/week 30 min	Your Rugged Constitution

Sample Weekly View

Day 1	Day 2	Day 3	Day 4	Day 5
Citizenship: Grade 7 (U.S.)				
Ethics: Part 1 Community Read Alouds: Grades 1-12		American Government: Grade 7		Plutarch: Grades 6-8 Current Events: Grades 5-8



Planning & Prep

Permission to print for non-commercial use. See Alveary group use policy to use lessons in a group context.

LINKS: Click text or scan the QR code in the top corner of the lesson plan pages to view online resources associated with the lessons.

Responsibility for previewing all links rests with the teacher. All links were checked at the time of publication; however, websites change frequently and may contain objectionable content. Please report broken links by contacting us through our website.

Citizenship: Grade 7 (U.S.)

☐ Make sure your student sets up a Citizenship Notebook. They will need a 3-ring binder, lined notebook paper, and 5 Tabbed Dividers. You can read more about how to set one up and suggestions for various sections in the document in Quick Links.

☐ As desired, plan for a read aloud time. Suggestions are provided in the Community Read

Aloud Quick Link, but local favorites are highly recommended whenever possible.

☐ Make a Calendar of Events for Current Events lessons by drawing a calendar grid in a notebook (or print a blank calendar from the internet).



Books & Resources

For book rationales and purchase options, click the Book List link or scan the QR code below.

∞ [View Book List Details](#)

American Government: Grade 7



Your Rugged Constitution



Supplies

For supply list details and basic supplies helpful to have on hand, click the links or scan the QR code below.

∞ [View Basic Supplies](#)

(No Subject Supplies Assigned)



Quick Links

(No Quick Links Assigned)

[Click THIS text
or scan the QR
code for links.](#)



American Government: Grade 7

How To Teach



Prepare

Plutarch: Teachers will find it helpful to preread the entire Life first, and then preread the day's passage before each lesson. Mark any passages that should be omitted due to content. (In Anne White's Plutarch Project books, the recommended source for this course, objectionable content has already been omitted.)

Current Events: Preview the news source for suitability.

Most other citizenship topics don't require additional prep.



Recap

Connect back to the previous lesson. (Optional for Current Events).



Introduce

For news sources, show students how to scan the headlines to get an overview first and then choose a story to read.

For Plutarch or other books: Use a picture, a map, or an engaging question to prepare students to receive the story as relevant. You may talk about one or two unfamiliar words that will be crucial to understanding. It is not necessary to cover all unfamiliar words.



Read

Read the selection assigned or the news story chosen. For rich, dense, or more challenging books such as *Ourselves* and *Plutarch*, it is a good idea to read them aloud. Have students keep an eye out for things to add to their Citizenship Notebook, *Book of Centuries*, and/or *Commonplace book*.



Narrate

Have the students narrate orally or in writing.



Discuss

Give students an opportunity to share their thoughts on the story and any connections made. For current events, look up where events occurred on a map and ask questions to help students discern the quality of the piece. (e.g., Are there sources cited? Is there an obvious bias? If so, what do other authors have to say on this subject? Are arguments supported by evidence? Is that evidence credible?) Consider reading an alternative perspective.



Citizenship Notebook

Have students record important ideas in their Citizenship Notebooks.

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[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)

QR

Term 1

WEEK 1

30m American Government: Grade 7 - Lesson 1

The Declaration of Independence

→ INTRO

What do we celebrate on July 4th each year?

→ VIEW

Watch this informative video about the Declaration of Independence.

∞ Video Link: The Declaration of Independence

→ READ

Now, use the link below to read parts of The Declaration of Independence. You don't need to read the whole thing. Try to read something from every section. Here is some background information about it. This document contains five parts. "The introduction 'declares' why the colonies need to be independent of the British Empire. Next, the Preamble explains views about freedom and self-rule. The First Section of the Body states the abuses of King George III, and the Second Section explains how the Colonists appealed in vain to the king, concluding that the United Colonies have the right to be free from the tyrant." (Painless American Government, p.23).

∞ Document Link: The Declaration of Independence

→ DISCUSS

Find a statement from the Declaration of Independence that you found interesting and discuss it with your teacher.

• EXTRA HELPING

View the home of Thomas Jefferson

∞ Image Link: Monticello on Carter Mountain

• IMPORTANT DATES

Declaration of Independence (1776)

WEEK 2

30m American Government: Grade 7 - Lesson 2

Types of Government

Materials: Our Rugged Constitution

→ RECAP

What do you remember about the Declaration of Independence?

→ INTRO

What kind of government does the United States have? There are three types of governments: 1. Autocracy- one ruler has absolute control and decision-making power 2. Oligarchy-a small group of landowners, military officers, or wealthy business people control the government institutions. 3. Democracy- The citizens together rule themselves (It comes from two Greek words—demos (the people) and kratos (rule of power). The Constitution establishes a federal democratic republic form of government. That is, we have a union of 50 sovereign States. It is a democracy because people govern themselves. It is representative because people choose elected officials by free and secret ballot. It is a republic because the government derives its power from the people.

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

p.1-12

∞ Image Link: Copy of the Constitution in The National Archives

→ VIEW & DISCUSS

Look at the map of the forms of government throughout the world. You may need an atlas to identify the specific countries.

∞ Map Link: Map: Forms of Government

→ CITIZENSHIP NOTEBOOK

Copy down the three branches of government shown on p.12 (illustrations optional). Leave plenty of room under each so you can add more details later.

• EXTRA HELPING

Watch this video for an explanation of how power is divided into the three branches of government.

∞ Video Link: How Power is Divided

• COMPOSITION

What were some of the issues the new country had to deal with? Why was a new governing document needed?

• IMPORTANT DATES

Signing of the Constitution (1787)

WEEK 3

30m American Government: Grade 7 - Lesson 3

Congress, House of Representatives

Materials: Our Rugged Constitution

→ RECAP

What did you read last time?

→ INTRO

The Constitution has become the world's oldest charter of national government in continuous use. With just 27 amendments (additions), it continues to provide the framework for our country.

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

p.13-23

• What do you notice about the differences between the House of Representatives and Senate?

→ CITIZENSHIP NOTEBOOK

• Go back to the chart you made in week 2 and add more information about Congress from this section, including requirements.

• Using the information from this map link, start another chart that lists the people currently in

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Term 1

Congress from your state who hold these government positions.
∞ Map Link: Map of Members of Congress
• See the example in Citizenship Notebook (Quick Links)

WEEK 4

30m American Government: Grade 7 - Lesson 4 *The Senate*

 Materials: Our Rugged Constitution

→ **RECAP**

What did you read last time?

→ **INTRO**

The "Great Compromise" allowed for large and small states to have equal representation in the Senate. We will read more today about the Great Compromise and the requirements for being a Senator.

→ **READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS** p.24-33

→ **VIEW & DISCUSS**

Read this article about the effects of "The Great Compromise" today.
∞ Article Link: 3-Minute Civics: Was the 'Great Compromise' great?
• Does the "great compromise" still make sense today?

• **EXTRA HELPING**

∞ **Video Link:** The Great Compromise

WEEK 5

30m American Government: Grade 7 - Lesson 5 *The Senate*

 Materials: Our Rugged Constitution

→ **RECAP**

What do you remember about The Great Compromise?

→ **INTRO**

"As the Constitution's framers sweated and fretted through the Philadelphia summer...the question of impeachment worried Benjamin Franklin. America's elder statesmen feared that without a means to remove a corrupt or incompetent official, the only resort would be assassination. As Franklin put it, this result would leave the political official 'not only deprived of his life but of the opportunity of vindicating his character.' Perhaps he had Julius Caesar and the Roman Senate in mind. Ultimately, the framers agreed with Franklin. There was some debate about which crimes would be impeachable, but the framers left us with 'Treason, Bribery or other High Crimes and Misdemeanors.' Though the first two are pretty clear-cut, the rest of the definition leaves considerably more wiggle room." (The History of American Impeachment, Kenneth Davis, Smithsonian Magazine)

→ **READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS** p.34-45

→ **VIEW & DISCUSS**

View this list of individuals impeached by the House of Representatives. How many were Presidents? (Note that President Richard Nixon resigned before he could be impeached.)
∞ Document Link: List of Individuals Impeached by the House of Representatives
• Is "Treason, Bribery or other High Crimes and Misdemeanors" clear enough, or should the Constitution be more clear on why someone can be impeached?

WEEK 6

30m American Government: Grade 7 - Lesson 6 *Rules for Congress*

 Materials: Our Rugged Constitution

→ **RECAP**

What did you read last time?

→ **INTRO**

This section outlines several rules for Congress. Do all of these rules still make sense today?

→ **READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS** p.46-53

The Congressional Record can now be viewed online. Look at a recent session and read the prayer that is recorded for that day.
∞ Document Link: Congressional Record (Click "Entire Issue" for the date you want to view.)
• Did any of the rules for Congress surprise you?
• Do you think it is still important for sessions to be in person, or should Congress be allowed to meet and vote online?

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Term 1

WEEK 7

30m American Government: Grade 7 - Lesson 7

Methods of Passing Laws

Materials: Our Rugged Constitution

→ RECAP

What did you read last time?

→ INTRO

Only about 10% of proposed bills become laws. Checks and balances are meant to help ensure no branch has too much power and can act too hastily.

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

p.54-63

→ VIEW & DISCUSS

Look at the current bills that have been submitted by Congress. Click on a couple of them to see what they are about.

∞ Document Link: Most Viewed Bills

• What might happen without a system of checks and balances?

→ CITIZENSHIP NOTEBOOK

Make a simple diagram showing how a bill becomes a law. This example is for state governments.

∞ Image Link: Chart of How a Bill Becomes a Law

• EXTRA HELPING

Watch the classic video about the way a bill becomes a law.

∞ Video Link: How A Bill Becomes A Law

WEEK 8

30m American Government: Grade 7 - Lesson 8

Powers of Congress

Materials: Our Rugged Constitution

→ RECAP

What did you read last time?

→ INTRO

How do you think Congress gets the money needed to run the government?

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

p.64-75

→ VIEW & DISCUSS

Watch this short video about the national debt and then view the U.S. National Debt Clock.

∞ Video Link: What is the National Debt?

∞ Image Link: U.S. National Debt Clock

→ CITIZENSHIP NOTEBOOK

In your notebook, list a few items that fall under the power of Congress that stood out to you the most.

• EXTRA HELPING

The Internal Revenue Service

∞ Video Link: The IRS Origin Story (especially to 1:30)

WEEK 9

30m American Government: Grade 7 - Lesson 9

Powers of Congress

Materials: Our Rugged Constitution

→ RECAP

What did you read last time?

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

p.76-83

Are there any powers of Congress surprising or confusing to you?

→ VIEW

In 2018, someone applied for the 10 millionth patent. A new patent design was created. Check out the video and timeline of important patents that were issued.

∞ Video Link: 10 Million Patents

→ CITIZENSHIP NOTEBOOK

In your notebook, list a few more items that fall under the power of Congress that stood out to you.

WEEK 10

30m American Government: Grade 7 - Lesson 10

Powers of Congress

Materials: Our Rugged Constitution

→ RECAP

What did you read last time?

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS



Term 1	
p.84-93 → CITIZENSHIP NOTEBOOK In your notebook, continue to list a few more items that fall under the power of Congress that stood out to you.	
WEEK 11  30m American Government: Grade 7 - Lesson 11 <i>Powers Denied the Federal Government & States</i>  Materials: Our Rugged Constitution → RECAP What did you read last time? → INTRO Have you heard the Latin term "habeas corpus"? Its literal meaning is "you may have the body". We will find out today why this unusual term is included in our Constitution. → READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS p.94-109 → VIEW & DISCUSS President Lincoln suspended the writ of habeas corpus during the Civil War. Watch this short video and discuss whether his actions were constitutional. ∞ Video Link: Suspending Habeas Corpus	
WEEK 12  30m American Government: Grade 7 - Lesson 12 <i>Exam Week</i> → EXAMS Answer question(s) related to the course. Questions will come from: Our Rugged Constitution	

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Term 2

WEEK 1 **30m American Government: Grade 7 - Lesson 13** *The President and Vice President*

 Materials: Our Rugged Constitution

→ **RECAP**

What did you read last time?

→ **INTRO**

How does someone become president? Is it the person who gets the highest number of votes? There is something called the electoral college that was written into the Constitution that makes it a little more complicated than just getting the most votes.

→ **READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS**

p.112-119

→ **VIEW & DISCUSS**

Watch this short video about the Electoral College

∞ Video Link: How the US Electoral College Works

→ **CITIZENSHIP NOTEBOOK**

Add information about the executive branch in your chart.

WEEK 2 **30m American Government: Grade 7 - Lesson 14** *Powers & Duties*

 Materials: Our Rugged Constitution

→ **RECAP**

What did you read last time?

→ **INTRO**

How has the role of the President changed since George Washington was first in office? What are some things that might be different for the current president than it was for George Washington?

→ **READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS**

p.120-129

The President's duties cover a lot of areas and require a lot of decisions. Presidents have a Cabinet, a group of experts in different areas who can inform the President as he makes decisions about what is best for the country. The word Cabinet is not in the Constitution, but "executive departments" are mentioned, which were the basis for the development of the Cabinet. President George Washington had four departments—the State Department (foreign nations), Treasury Department (money matters), War Department (military matters), and Department of Justice (legal matters). Now, the president has 15 executive departments.

→ **VIEW & DISCUSS**

Watch this short video explaining the President's Cabinet.

∞ Video Link: The President's Cabinet

→ **CITIZENSHIP NOTEBOOK**

- Add information about the role of the president.
 - Make a list of at least 4 of the Cabinet positions in the government and who serves in those roles.
- ∞ Document Link: List of Cabinet Members

WEEK 3 **30m American Government: Grade 7 - Lesson 15** *Powers & Duties*

 Materials: Our Rugged Constitution

→ **RECAP**

What did you read last time?

→ **INTRO**

Today we will read about more powers and duties of the President, but we'll also explore why Presidents today may have more power than the Constitution intended.

→ **READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS**

p.130-135

→ **VIEW & DISCUSS**

Watch this video on the expanding powers of the presidency. Stop around the 4:38 mark to allow time for discussion.

∞ Video Link: Is Expanding Presidential Power Bad?

- Do you think Presidents today have more power than the Constitution intended? Why might this be good or bad?

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Term 2

→ CITIZENSHIP NOTEBOOK

Add information about the powers and duties of the president.

WEEK 4

30m American Government: Grade 7 - Lesson 16

More Powers & Duties

Materials: Our Rugged Constitution

→ RECAP

What did you read last time?

→ INTRO

What do you remember about the duties of the President and how they have changed? Today we will read more about those duties.

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

p.136-141

→ VIEW & DISCUSS

Visit The White House website "Briefing Room". Pick a recent press briefing or speech to read.

∞ Document Link: The White House Briefing Room

→ CITIZENSHIP NOTEBOOK

Add information about the powers and duties of the president.

WEEK 5

30m American Government: Grade 7 - Lesson 17

Federal Courts & Judges

Materials: Our Rugged Constitution

→ RECAP

What did you read last time?

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

p.144-147

• How does a case end up at the Supreme Court? Only about 1% of cases that appeal to the Supreme Court are chosen to be argued before the justices.

∞ Article Link: Supreme Court Information

→ VIEW & DISCUSS

Watch this video that explains the process of how a case ends up in the Supreme Court.

∞ Video Link: How a Case Ends up in the Supreme Court.

→ CITIZENSHIP NOTEBOOK

Add information about the Judicial Branch.

• EXTRA HELPING

Marbury v. Madison was the Supreme Court case that established judicial review. Judicial review is the role of the courts in interpreting law according to the Constitution.

∞ Video Link: Marbury v. Madison

WEEK 6

30m American Government: Grade 7 - Lesson 18

Cases in Federal Court

Materials: Our Rugged Constitution

→ RECAP

What did you read last time?

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

p.148-155

How would you describe treason? Is it criticizing the government?

→ VIEW

Look through the list of Supreme Court Justices and scan their biographies. You will be writing some information about them in your notebook.

∞ Video Link: Current Members of the Supreme Court

→ CITIZENSHIP NOTEBOOK

Write the names of the current Supreme Court Justices, when they began, which President nominated them and anything else you find interesting from their bio.

• EXTRA HELPING

If you have more questions about the Supreme Court, there is a list of frequently asked questions on their website.

∞ Link: FAQ about Supreme Court

WEEK 7

30m American Government: Grade 7 - Lesson 19

State Duties to Other States

Materials: Our Rugged Constitution

→ RECAP

What did you read last time?

→ INTRO

As a republic, we are not just one big country but also a union, or group, of individual states. Today we will read about some of the ways the states interact.

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Term 2

→ **READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS**
p.158-163

→ **VIEW**
∞ Video Link: Article IV Explained (Stop video at 3:04 or watch further as time permits.)

→ **CITIZENSHIP NOTEBOOK**
Add the "wedding cake" example of Federalism from today's video to your notebook.

WEEK 8

30m American Government: Grade 7 - Lesson 20
New States & Federal Territories

Materials: Our Rugged Constitution

→ **RECAP**
What did you read last time?

→ **INTRO**
Last time we read about some ways states interact with each other. Today we will see an example of how an amendment can greatly affect those interactions.

→ **READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS**
p.164-169

→ **VIEW**
View the list of US Territories. Then view the map of where these territories are located. Can you make any speculations based on their locations?
∞ Document Link: US Territories
∞ Map Link: US Territories Map

→ **CITIZENSHIP NOTEBOOK**
Make a list of the rules that exist to keep peace between the states.

WEEK 9

30m American Government: Grade 7 - Lesson 21
The Making of Amendments

Materials: Our Rugged Constitution

→ **RECAP**
What did you read last time?

→ **INTRO**
We saw last reading how an amendment can change the way we do things. We will dig more into amendments and how they are made today.

→ **READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS**
p.172-179

COMPOSITION PROMPT

- Why do you think it is so hard to add an amendment to the Constitution?
- Why did the framers of the Constitution add the clause so that there could be amendments added?

WEEK 10

30m American Government: Grade 7 - Lesson 22
The Supremacy of the Constitution

Materials: Our Rugged Constitution

→ **RECAP**
What did you read last time?

→ **INTRO**
In our reading today, we will read about our government paying back debt and abiding by its treaties. A treaty is a formal agreement between countries. Paying back money and keeping to our agreements are important parts of building trust, whether with other people or other nations.

→ **READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS**
p.182-189
What do you think the decision of our government to pay back the full amount of debt says about the kind of character our founders wanted for our country?

WEEK 11

30m American Government: Grade 7 - Lesson 23
The Ratification of the Constitution

Materials: Our Rugged Constitution

→ **RECAP**
What did you read last time?

→ **INTRO**
Our founders had met together over a very hot summer, and after much arguing, debating, and compromising, they had agreed upon the Constitution. Now, all they had to do was get the people of the states to agree on it, too! We'll read about that today.

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Term 2	
→ READ & NARRATE p.190-193 → VIEW ∞ Video Link: How to Ratify the Constitution → DISCUSS Why do you think some people feared the new government and wanted protections from the government written into the Constitution?	
WEEK 12 30m American Government: Grade 7 - Lesson 24 Exam Week → EXAMS Answer question(s) related to the course. Questions will come from: Our Rugged Constitution	

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Term 3

WEEK 1 30m American Government: Grade 7 - Lesson 25 Amendment 1

Materials: Our Rugged Constitution

PREP: You might want to read this article and share some thoughts with your student to give a little more background information about this idea of "separation of church and state" which is not found in the Constitution but stated often when discussing the First Amendment.
∞ Article Link: The History and Meaning Behind Separation of Church and State.

→ INTRO

Have you heard the phrase "separation of church and state"? What might that mean? It is not in the Constitution, but people often think it is because of the First Amendment. It was in a letter that President Thomas Jefferson wrote in 1802, a letter that said the establishment clause in the First Amendment should represent a "wall of separation" between church and state. We will explore what that means and how people might interpret it differently.

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

- p.196-197
 - Do you think a football coach has the right to kneel on the football field after a game at a public school and pray to God? The school didn't think so. He was fired from his job for refusing to stop this action and his case went all the way to the Supreme Court. We will read an article about the case and see what the Supreme Court decided after many years of legal battles.
∞ Article Link: At Long Last, a Victory for Coach Kennedy
- Do you agree with the Supreme Court's decision? Explain.
 - Can you give examples of the other freedoms we have according to this amendment?

→ CITIZENSHIP NOTEBOOK

Write down the safeguards given in the 1st Amendment in your own words or in bullet points. Draw a picture or symbol to represent what they mean.

→ NOTE

There is not time in this term's lessons to fully explore each Amendment. If interest is high, you will find many links and court cases for afternoon exploration and family discussions in Extra Helpings.

• EXTRA HELPING

The legal docket is a podcast highlighting cases brought to the Supreme Court. You can learn more about Kennedy v. Bremerton School District. (Audio or transcript)
∞ **Audio Link:** Legal Docket podcast

• COMPOSITION - Interview Coach Joe Kennedy about his Supreme Court case.

WEEK 2 30m American Government: Grade 7 - Lesson 26 Amendments 2-4

Materials: Our Rugged Constitution

→ INTRO

Do you know what the Second Amendment is? This is a hotly debated topic that comes up a lot in the news. We will look at a recent case that was decided in June 2022 by the Supreme Court. You can listen to the podcast about it, which has the audio from the actual court case, or read the transcript.

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

- p.198-203
 - Read
∞ Article Link: Self-defense at the Supreme Court (stop at 9:30)
- What do you think the Supreme Court decided? (They decided in favor of Robert Nash. The vote was 6-3. The court said that New York's proper-cause requirement violates the Fourteenth Amendment by preventing law-abiding citizens with ordinary self-defense needs from exercising their Second Amendment right to keep and bear arms in public for self-defense.)

→ CITIZENSHIP NOTEBOOK

Write down the 2nd-4th Amendments in your own words or in bullet points. Draw a picture or symbol to represent what it means.

• EXTRA HELPING

Here is the link if you want to listen to the entire podcast about this case.
∞ **Podcast Link:** Jumping the Gun

WEEK 3 30m American Government: Grade 7 - Lesson 27 Amendments 5-8

Materials: Our Rugged Constitution

→ RECAP

What did you read last time?

→ INTRO

Maybe you've heard anyone say, "I plead the fifth!" If so, you might know something about this next Amendment.

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

p.204-211
Why do you think the Bill of Rights says so much about the rights of people who have to go to court?

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Term 3

→ CITIZENSHIP NOTEBOOK

Write down the 5th -8th Amendments in your own words or in bullet points. Draw a picture or symbol to represent what it means.

WEEK 4

30m American Government: Grade 7 - Lesson 28

Amendments 9-10

Materials: Our Rugged Constitution

→ RECAP

What did you read last time?

→ INTRO

We read a lot last time about the rights that our Constitution lists for people being accused of crimes. Today we will read about where our rights come from. Spoiler alert: it's not the government!

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

p.212-217

On p.216 our book says, "The people have rights that come before the rights of the government. The people's rights come from God and cannot be taken away by human laws." What do you think of this statement?

→ CITIZENSHIP NOTEBOOK

Write down the 9th and 10th Amendments in your own words or in bullet points. Draw a picture or symbol to represent what it means.

WEEK 5

30m American Government: Grade 7 - Lesson 29

Amendments 11-13

Materials: Our Rugged Constitution

→ RECAP

What did you read last time?

→ INTRO

Last time, we read about where our rights come from. Today, we will read about when our country officially decided that those rights were for all people.

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

p.220-227

→ VIEW

∞ Video Link: The 13th Amendment

• The video presents a controversial "loophole" of the 13th Amendment - forcing prisoners to work without pay. What are your thoughts on this issue?

→ CITIZENSHIP NOTEBOOK

Write down the 11th-13th Amendments in your own words or in bullet points. Draw a picture or symbol to represent what it means.

WEEK 6

30m American Government: Grade 7 - Lesson 30

Amendment 14

Materials: Our Rugged Constitution

→ RECAP

What did you read last time?

→ INTRO

How does someone become a citizen of the United States? Do you know someone born in another country who became a US citizen? We will read about that today.

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

p.228-235

Here are the requirements for becoming a naturalized citizen:

- Be at least 18 years old
- Be a legal resident of the United States for 3-5 or more years
- Be of good moral character and be loyal to the United States
- Be able to read, write, and speak basic English
- Pass a naturalization test
- Take the Oath of Allegiance at a naturalization ceremony

→ READ

Do you think you could pass the Naturalization Test? Look at some of the questions to see what people need to know about the US before becoming citizens.

∞ Article Link: Questions for Naturalization Test

• EXTRA HELPING

Brown v. Board of Education is a landmark Supreme Court case decided by the 14th Amendment.

∞ Video Link: Brown v. Board of Education

Term 3

→ CITIZENSHIP NOTEBOOK

Write down the 14th Amendment in your own words or in bullet points. Draw a picture or symbol to represent what it means.

WEEK 7

30m American Government: Grade 7 - Lesson 31

Amendments 15 and 16

Materials: Our Rugged Constitution

→ RECAP

What did you read last time?

→ INTRO

In 1913, two very important amendments were passed. One changed how Senators are elected. The other established a Federal Income Tax. (I wonder how popular that one was!)

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

p.236-241

What do you think would happen if there was no Federal Income tax?

→ CITIZENSHIP NOTEBOOK

Write down the 15th-17th Amendments in your own words or in bullet points. Draw a picture or symbol to represent what it means.

WEEK 8

30m American Government: Grade 7 - Lesson 32

Amendment 17 and 18

Materials: Our Rugged Constitution

→ RECAP

What did you read last time?

→ INTRO

From the years 1920-1933, due to the 18th Amendment, the production and sale of alcohol was prohibited. The Temperance (means abstaining from alcohol) Movement was a group of people that fought for this amendment for many years because of the negative effects that drunkenness had on families and work environments. This time period is called Prohibition. Although many people followed this law, there were many others who made alcohol illegally and there were even clubs called speakeasies where people would drink alcohol. It was a hard law to enforce. In 1933, the 21st Amendment repealed it, and it was no longer illegal to buy and sell alcohol. The states could make their own laws about the sale of alcohol.

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

p.240-243

- What does the Bible say about the drinking of alcohol?
- Why do you think it was a hard law to enforce?

→ CITIZENSHIP NOTEBOOK

Write down the 17th and 18th Amendments in your own words or in bullet points. Draw a picture or symbol to represent what it means.

WEEK 9

30m American Government: Grade 7 - Lesson 33

Amendments 19-22

Materials: Our Rugged Constitution

→ RECAP

What did you read last time?

→ INTRO

Have you heard the term suffrage? It comes from Latin and has to do with the right to vote. So people who fight for the right to vote are suffragists.

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

p.244-253

→ VIEW & DISCUSS

Watch this 5 minute video about the 19th Amendment.

∞ Video Link: 19th Amendment

- Why do you think the western states were the first to allow women the right to vote?
- How did WW1 impact the 19th Amendment?

→ CITIZENSHIP NOTEBOOK

Write down the amendments in your own words or in bullet points. Draw a picture or symbol to represent what it means.

Term 3

WEEK 10 30m American Government: Grade 7 - Lesson 34 Amendments 23-24

Materials: Our Rugged Constitution

→ RECAP

What did you read last time?

→ INTRO

Voting is an extremely important right in a democratic republic. Today we will read more about how the Constitution protects that right.

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

p.254-257

How do you think it felt to live in Washington DC and not be able to vote in Presidential races? Are there any circumstances today that might keep some people from voting?

→ CITIZENSHIP NOTEBOOK

Write down the 23rd and 24th Amendments in your own words or in bullet points. Draw a picture or symbol to represent what it means.

WEEK 11 30m American Government: Grade 7 - Lesson 35 Amendments 25-26

Materials: Our Rugged Constitution

→ RECAP

What did you read last time?

→ INTRO

One of today's amendments changed the minimum voting age from 21 to 18. During the Vietnam War, our country drafted young men to fight for our country who were not old enough to vote. Let's read about the Amendment that changed that.

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

1. p.258-262

Approximately 11,848 amendments to the Constitution have been proposed through 2019, averaging over 100 annually!

2. Read these examples of proposed amendments. Do you think these 5 should be enacted? Can you think of others you might suggest?

∞ Document Link: Proposed Amendments to the Constitution

∞ Document Link: Five Proposed Amendments

→ CITIZENSHIP NOTEBOOK

Write down the 25th and 26th Amendments in your own words or in bullet points. Draw a picture or symbol to represent what it means.

WEEK 12 30m American Government: Grade 7 - Lesson 36 Exam Week

→ EXAMS

Answer question(s) related to the course.

Questions will come from:

Our Rugged Constitution

American Government: Grade 7

Examination

- Term 1** · Our Rugged Constitution: Tell all you know about the powers of Congress.
- Term 2** · Our Rugged Constitution: Tell all you know about one of the branches of the government and the qualifications, roles, and limits for that position.
- Term 3** · Our Rugged Constitution: Pick one of the rights that citizens have according to the First Amendment (freedom of religion, speech, press, and assembly) and explain what that means, and provide examples of what is allowed according to that right.